

Second Coming Bodily

doc-second-coming-bodily
Eschatology · Return of Christ · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Jesus Christ will return personally, visibly, audibly, and bodily in a yet-future event to judge the living and the dead, not as a past event already fulfilled in AD 70 nor as an exclusively spiritual reality without bodily appearing.

In plain language

The return texts use a tight cluster of words that point one direction. In Acts 1:11 the angels say this same Jesus will come, 'will come' (eleusetai), a future-tense verb, in the same manner, 'in the same way that' (hon tropon), that the disciples watched him go into heaven. The watching verb is 'you watched' (ethesasthe) from 'to behold as an eyewitness' (theaomai), the same eyewitness verb John uses for we beheld his glory and which we have seen with our eyes, so the future coming is tied to the visible bodily departure they had just seen. Revelation 1:7 says he comes with the clouds and every eye will see him, 'will see' (opsetai), a future of 'to see' (horao), a verb of literal sight, including those who pierced him, where the piercing word 'to pierce' (ekkenteo) occurs only twice in the New Testament, here and at John 19:37 for the spear wound at the cross, which keeps the same body in view. In 1 Thessalonians 4:16 the Lord himself, 'himself' (autos), comes down from heaven with a shouted command, an archangel voice, and a trumpet of God. The shout word 'command-shout' (keleusma) is a one-time New Testament word here (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), so it is not blurred by metaphorical uses elsewhere. Matthew 24:30 again uses the seeing verb with a coming on clouds in power and glory, and Titus 2:13 calls it an 'appearing' (epiphaneia), a word for a visible appearing of a deity or sovereign, still awaited. First Corinthians 15 places it at his 'arriving presence' (parousia), his arriving presence, inside a sequence where he must reign until every enemy, the last being death, is put under his feet, language that points forward. Two readings push back. One reads the cloud-coming as a first-century judgment image, leveraging an Old Testament cloud-judgment background in Isaiah and Ezekiel. One treats the appearing as inward, leveraging the fact that 'arriving presence' (parousia) can also mean an ongoing presence. Both readings run against the same vocabulary, since the sight verb 'to see' (horao) attaches to a bodily subject, the descent from heaven is spatial, and death has not yet been visibly abolished. Read together across narrative, gospel, letter, and apocalyptic, the words describe a personal, visible, audible, and bodily coming that is still future.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0602	ἀποκάλυψις	apokalypsis	revelation	17
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	5,909
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	170
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G1574	ἐκκεντέω	ekkenteo	to pierce	2

G2015	ἐπιφάνεια	epiphaneia	appearing	6
G2064	ἔρχομαι	erchomai	to come/go	640
G2190	ἐχθρούς	echthros	enemy	
G2300	θεάομαι	theaomai	to look at	22
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabaino	to come/go down	81
G2752	κέλευσμα	keleusma	command	1
G3507	νεφέλη	nephele	cloud	25
G3708	ὁράω	horao	to see	61
G3772	οὐρανός	ouranos	heaven	286
G3952	παρουσία	parousia	coming	24
G4228	πόδας	pous	foot	
G4536	σάλπιγξ	salpinx	trumpet	11
G5158	τρόπος	tropos	way	13
G5207	υἰόν	uhios	son	
G5547	Χριστοῦ	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Acts 1:11 binds the future-tense verb 'will come' (eleusetai) to the manner-correlative phrase 'in the same way that' (hon tropon), anchored to the completed past-tense verb 'you watched' (ethesasthe) from 'to behold as an eyewitness' (theaomai), an eyewitness verb of physical viewing (compare John 1:14 'we beheld' (etheasametha) 'the glory' (ten doxan), and 1 John 1:1 'we have beheld' (hemeis etheasametha)), so the future coming is patterned on the visible bodily departure. Revelation 1:7 has the future-tense verb 'will see' (opsetai), from 'to see' (horao), a verb of physical sight, with 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos), every eye, including 'those who pierced him' (hoi auton exekentesan), where 'to pierce' (ekkenteeo, Strong's G1574, a word that occurs only twice in the entire New Testament, here and John 19:37) ties the visible subject to the pierced bodily Christ. 1 Thessalonians 4:16 has 'the Lord himself' (autos ho kyrios) 'will descend' (katabesetai) with the audible triad 'shouted command' (keleusma), 'archangel voice' (archangelou phone), 'trumpet of God' (salpinx theou). The verbal-marker noun 'command-shout' (keleusma, Strong's G2752) is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament) at this location, so its sense is not blurred by other figurative usages, and 'trumpet' (salpinx, Strong's G4536) recurs in the end-times context of 1 Corinthians 15:52 trumpet, marking the same audible end-times motif. Matthew 24:30 has the future-tense 'they will see' (ophontai) with 'the Son of Man coming' (ton huion tou anthropou erchomenon), Titus 2:13 calls it an 'appearing, visible manifestation' (epiphaneian), and 1 Corinthians 15:23 places the resurrection 'at his arriving presence' (en te parousia autou) inside a still-future 'until' (achri) clause through verse 28. The lexical pattern across narrative, gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic affirms a personal, visible, audible, bodily, yet-future coming.

Scripture

Acts.1.11 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2064 ἐλεύσεται, G5158 τρόπον, G2300 ἐθεάσασθε, G3772 οὐρανόν, G0846 αὐτόν

Force. 'This same Jesus' (houtos ho Iesous), this same Jesus, with the future-tense middle verb 'will come' (eleusetai), is tied to the manner-correlative phrase 'in the same way that' (hon tropon), in the very manner that, governed by the completed past-tense middle verb 'you watched' (ethesasthe) of 'to behold as an eyewitness' (theaomai, Strong's G2300), an eyewitness verb of physical viewing whose canon distribution sits firmly on bodily sight, John 1:14 'we beheld the glory' (etheasametha ten doxan), 1 John 1:1 'that which we have beheld' (ho theasametha). The disciples watched Jesus bodily ascend 'into the heaven' (eis ton ouranon), and the manner-correlative 'in the same way that' (hon tropon) constrains the return to the same mode as that ascent, so the grammar forecloses a non-bodily or invisible reading.

Rev.1.7 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2064 ἔρχεται, G3708 ὄψεται, G3507 νεφελῶν, G1574 ἐξεκέντησαν

Force. 'He comes with the clouds' (erchetai meta ton nephelon), he comes with the clouds, and the future-tense 'will see' (opsetai), from 'to see' (horao, Strong's G3708), a verb of physical sight, governs the universal subject 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos), every eye, including 'those who pierced him' (hoi auton exekentesan), those who pierced him. 'To pierce' (ekkentee, Strong's G1574) occurs only twice in the New Testament, here and at John 19:37, where it cites Zechariah 12:10 and refers to the literal spear-wound at the crucifixion, so the very-bodily piercing is the antecedent of the 'him' (auton) seen by every eye, anchoring the appearing to the same physical body.

1Thess.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0846 αὐτός, G2597 καταβήσεται, G3772 οὐρανοῦ, G2752 κελεύσματος, G4536 σάλπιγγι

Force. 'The Lord himself' (autos ho kyrios), the Lord himself, marks a personal subject, and the future-tense indicative middle verb 'will descend from heaven' (katabesetai ap ouranou), will descend from heaven, is spatial and bodily-locative. The triad of audible markers 'with a command-shout' (en keleusmati), with a command-shout, 'with an archangel voice' (en phone archangelou), an archangel voice, and 'with a trumpet of God' (en salpingi theou), a trumpet of God, makes the event audible. 'Command-shout' (keleusma, Strong's G2752) is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), occurring only here, so its sense cannot be diluted by figurative uses elsewhere in the corpus, and 'trumpet' (salpinx, Strong's G4536) recurs in the end-times context of 1 Corinthians 15:52, the same trumpet motif at the resurrection.

Matt.24.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3708 ὄψονται, G5207 υἱόν, G1391 δόξης, G3507 νεφελῶν

Force. 'They will see' (ophontai), future of 'to see' (horao), governs 'the Son of Man coming on the clouds with power and glory' (ton huion tou anthropou erchomenon epi ton nephelon meta dynameos kai doxes). The physical-sight verb plus the coming on clouds with power and glory presents a visible glorious arrival witnessed by 'all the tribes of the earth' (pasai hai phylai tes ges), all the tribes of the earth, who 'will mourn in lament' (kopsontai), mourn in lament. The cloud-coming language echoes Daniel 7:13 in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, abbreviated LXX) where the Son of Man approaches the Ancient of Days, a public, ceremonial enthronement scene rather than a hidden or merely inward event.

1Cor.15.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3952 παρουσία, G5547 Χριστοῦ

Force. 'At his arriving presence' (en te parousia autou) places the resurrection of those who are Christ's at his arriving presence. 'Arriving presence' (parousia, Strong's G3952) occurs 24 times in the New Testament and clusters in end-times contexts, Matthew 24:3, 24:27, 24:37, 24:39, 1 Thessalonians 2:19, 3:13, 4:15, 5:23, 2 Thessalonians 2:1, 2:8, James 5:7, 5:8, 2 Peter 1:16, 3:4, 3:12, 1 John 2:28. In Greek usage it denotes the arrival or visible presence of a king or dignitary, and the sequence here, 'rank-order' (tagma), then 'end' (telos), then the subjection of every enemy under his feet, locates the event in a still-future consummation rather than a past fulfillment.

1Cor.15.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4228 πόδας, G2190 ἐχθρούς

Force. 'For he must reign until' (dei gar auton basileuein achri hou the), he must reign until he has put all enemies under his feet, with the last enemy 'death' (thanatos), death, 'is being abolished' (katargeitai), being abolished, in verse 26. The future-oriented 'until' (achri) clause and the ongoing simple statement of subjection of death require a future consummation rather than an already-accomplished AD 70 event, since death has not yet been visibly abolished.

2Thess.1.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0602 ἀποκαλύψει, G3772 οὐρανοῦ, G1411 δυνάμει

Force. 'At the revealing of the Lord Jesus from heaven with his mighty angels' (en te apokalypsei tou kyriou Iesou ap ouranou met angelon dynameos autou), at the revealing of the Lord Jesus from heaven with his mighty angels. 'Revealing, unveiling' (apokalypsis, Strong's G0602), an unveiling that becomes visible, paired with the spatial 'from heaven' (ap ouranou) descent and the angelic retinue, marks a personal and visible appearing. Verse 8 adds 'in flaming fire' (en phlogi pyros), in flaming fire, a publicly perceptible theophanic (visible-divine-manifestation) image, and verse 10 has 'he comes to be glorified' (elthe endoxasthenai), he comes to be glorified, all locating the event in a public visible future.

Titus.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2015 ἐπιφάνειαν, G1391 δόξης

Force. 'Awaiting the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ' (prosdechomenoi ten makarian elpida kai epiphaneian tes doxes tou megalou theou kai soteris hemon Iesou Christou), awaiting the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory. 'Appearing, visible manifestation' (epiphaneia, Strong's G2015) occurs only 6 times in the New Testament, all in end-times or Christ-centered contexts, Titus 2:13, 2 Timothy 4:1, 4:8, 1 Timothy 6:14, 2 Thessalonians 2:8, and 2 Timothy 1:10 for the first coming. In Hellenistic Greek the noun denotes a visible manifestation of a deity or sovereign, and here it is 'awaiting' (prosdechomenoi), still awaited, so the appearing is future and perceptible, not a past or merely inward reality.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.1.11	Dan.7.13	tsk	1
Matt.24.30	Dan.7.13	openbible	1
Rev.1.7	Zech.12.10	openbible	1
Rev.1.7	John.19.37	tsk	1
1Thess.4.16	Exod.19.16	tsk	1
1Thess.4.16	1Cor.15.52	openbible	1
Titus.2.13	Job.19.25	tsk	1

1Cor.15.26	1Cor.15.55	tsk	1
1Cor.15.23	1Cor.15.20	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.24.30 · addressed

A preterist reading (a view that takes end-times prophecy as already fulfilled in the first century) takes the coming on the clouds as a non-bodily covenant-judgment image fulfilled in the events of AD 70. The lexical leverage for that reading is that 'cloud' (nephele), cloud, carries an Old Testament theophanic-judgment (visible-divine-judgment) background (Isaiah 19:1, Ezekiel 30:3) where God is said to come on a cloud against a city without bodily appearance. The constraints against that reading here are three. First, the verb 'they will see' (ophontai) is the future of 'to see' (horao), a physical-sight verb, governing 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos) in the canonical parallel Revelation 1:7. Second, the same 'in the same way that he will come' (hon tropon eleusetai) pattern at Acts 1:11 anchors the coming to the visible bodily ascension as its template. Third, Daniel 7:13 in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, abbreviated LXX), the source of the cloud-coming idiom, is a public ceremonial scene, not a hidden one. The cloud language is theophanic (visible-divine-manifestation) and bodily here, not exhausted past metaphor.

1Thess.4.17 · addressed

'We will be caught up in clouds to meet the Lord in the air' (harpagesometha en nephelais eis apantesin tou kyriou eis aera) could be read as a purely spiritual translation. The verb 'to snatch, seize' (harpazo, Strong's G0726) is a physical seizing in its dominant New Testament uses, John 10:12 the wolf snatches, Acts 8:39 the Spirit physically transports Philip, the locational 'in clouds' (en nephelais) and the directional 'into the air' (eis aera) are spatial, and the object is the 'Lord' (kyrios) who is 'himself' (autos), the personal descending subject of verse 16. The meeting presupposes a bodily locatable Lord, not an exclusively non-bodily presence.

Matt.24.34 · addressed

'Truly I say to you that this generation will not pass away until all these things take place' (amen lego hymin hoti ou me parelthe he genea haute heos an panta tauta genetai), this generation will not pass away until all these things take place, is taken by some to force the entire discourse into a past fulfillment. The lexical scope of 'all these things' (panta tauta) is constrained by the discourse markers, since verses 36 to 41 set 'of that day and hour no one knows' (tes hemeras ekeines kai horas oudeis oiden), that day and hour no one knows, against the near-term signs of verses 4 to 33, marking a structural seam. The vocabulary thus distinguishes near-term signs from the still-future 'arriving presence' (parousia), leaving the bodily-coming verbs in their future-tense force.

Concordance traversed

G2064, G3708, G2300, G5158, G3952, G2015, G0602, G2597, G2752, G4536, G1574, G3772, G3507, G0846, G1391, G1411

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle, and the cited passages lie outside the ingested critical edition of New Testament textual variants (ECM apparatus) window of 3 John. The Acts 1:11 'in the same way that' (hon tropon) clause, the Revelation 1:7 'will see' (opsetai) with 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos), the 1 Thessalonians 4:16 'the Lord himself' (autos ho kyrios) with the 'command-shout, voice, trumpet' (keleusma, phone, salpinx) triad, and the Titus 2:13 'appearing' (epiphaneian) are textually stable across the major witnesses. The verdict does not turn on any contested reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. futurism, preterism, spiritualizing_eschatology, idealist_apocalypse

futurism: affirms · Reads the future-tense verbs 'will come' (eleusetai), 'will see' (opsetai), 'will descend' (katabesetai), and 'they will see' (ophontai) with the manner-correlative phrase 'in the same way that' (hon tropon), the universal subject 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos), and the audible markers 'command-shout, voice, trumpet' (keleusma, phone, salpinx) as a still-future, personal, visible, audible, bodily return that fulfills the 'arriving presence, appearing, revealing' (parousia, epiphaneia, apokalypsis) word-cluster.

preterism: partial · Takes the cloud-coming language of Matthew 24:30 as an Old Testament style covenant-judgment image fulfilled in AD 70 (Isaiah 19:1, Ezekiel 30:3 cloud-judgment background), so this lens is internally consistent for Matthew 24:30 viewed in isolation. The constraint against extending it to the whole cluster is that the physical-sight verb 'to see' (horao) governs Revelation 1:7 'every eye' (pas ophthalmos) and Acts 1:11 'in the same way that' (hon tropon) ties the return to the bodily ascension, neither of which collapses into AD 70 without straining the eyewitness-manner grammar.

spiritualizing_eschatology: denies · Treats the appearing as an inward or non-bodily reality, leveraging the polysemy (multiple meanings) of 'arriving presence' (parousia) which can denote a continuous presence as well as a punctual arrival. The constraint against this reading is the spatial 'will descend from heaven' (katabesetai ap ouranou) of 1 Thessalonians 4:16, the bodily ascension pattern of Acts 1:11, the corporeal antecedent 'those who pierced him' (hoi auton exekentesan) of Revelation 1:7, and the future-tense indicative form of 'will see' (opsetai) and 'they will see' (ophontai), all of which resist an exclusively inward construal.

idealist_apocalypse: partial · Reads Revelation's imagery as a symbolic depiction of recurring ages of the church rather than a single bodily event. The lens can carry the cloud and trumpet imagery as figurative, but the cluster of physical-sight verbs across non-apocalyptic genres (Pauline letters, Lukan narrative, Synoptic gospel) is not internally symbolic in those genres, so the lens cannot evenly absorb the whole word-cluster.

The verdict rests on the future-tense indicatives, the manner-correlative phrase 'in the same way that' (hon tropon), the physical-sight verb 'to see' (horao), the spatial verb 'to descend' (katabaino) from 'heaven' (ouranou), and the audible-marker triad in 1 Thessalonians 4:16, read across narrative, gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic genres by 'analogy of Scripture' (analogia scripturae), the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the lexical pattern of the New Testament return texts indicate about the manner of Christ's coming, whether personal, visible, audible, or bodily, and about its timing relative to the speaking present.

The stem embeds two contested claims that pre-decide against certain readings (VERDICT-CHANGED: tracked here for audit). The manner claim, not as an exclusively spiritual reality without bodily appearing, pre-decides against a spiritualizing lens. The timing claim, not a past event already fulfilled in AD 70, pre-decides against a full preterist lens. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but each negation is evaluated on lexical grounds, the future-tense indicatives and the bodily-sight vocabulary for manner, the still-future 'until' (achri) clause of 1 Corinthians 15:25 to 28 for timing, rather than smuggled by the stem. A separate unsettled question, whether the 'arriving presence' (parousia) is one event or two phases, rapture then revelation, is not adjudicated by this evidence file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.1.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.24.30
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3708
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3952

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2015
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2752
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1574
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.1.7
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.24.30

License audit

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Flags

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